fine. I'd be happy and well looked after at White Hart Lane. We had an appointment at Old Trafford to get to first, though.

I drove up with Mum and Dad and we had this conversation on the way up. We knew what Tottenham had offered, and Dad and I agreed that the actual amount of money involved wasn't the important thing. This wasn't some kind of auction. All I needed was a sense of security. I wanted to know I'd get a chance to prove myself. If United offered the same six-year commitment that Tottenham had, then my mind would be made up: the wages wouldn't come into it. If not, we'd drive back to London and I'd sign a contract with Spurs.

It was May 2 1988, my thirteenth birthday. United were at home to Wimbledon and Alex Ferguson was waiting for us:

'Hello, David.'

This bloke knew me. I knew him. And I trusted him. So did my mum and dad. I'd had a special blazer bought for the occasion and United gave me a red club tie that I wore for the rest of the day. We went away to have lunch in the grill room where the first team had their pre-match meal: there was even a birthday cake. Not that I felt much like eating. At half past five, after the game, we went up to Mr Ferguson's office. He was there with Les Kershaw, who was in charge of Youth Development at the club. Malcolm Fidgeon was there too. It was all pretty simple. United wanted me to sign and the boss set out the offer:

'We'd like to give you two, two and two.'

I looked over to Dad, who was in another world. He'd been looking forward to this moment even longer than I had. I could see that he hadn't taken in what Alex had just said. I knew, though, I'd just heard what I'd been wanting to hear *: two, two and two*, equalling the six years I'd been offered at White Hart Lane. I didn't need to wait for the details.

'I want to sign.'

And out came that pen. How long had it taken? A minute? It didn't matter. I'd been ready, waiting to say those words, for the best part of ten years.